THE $1M ARR CHANNEL MAP

Every channel B2B startups use to get from zero to $1M ARR, with what each one costs, how fast it moves, and the three things to do this week to start it.

WHAT THIS IS

I'm a partner at RallyUp. We pivoted to an agency on 1 May 2026 with almost nothing, and we have grown every month since.

This is the map I wish we'd had on day one. Fifteen channels, each with what it is, how fast it moves, what it costs, three first steps and the mistake that kills it.

> **The honest promise.** Nobody gets to $1M ARR on fifteen channels. You get there on two or three, done properly for a long time. Use this to pick them. The speed and cost labels are my rules of thumb from running these for founders, not benchmarks.

HOW TO PICK YOUR TWO

1. **Need customers this month?** Start with warm intros, founder dinners or newsletter ads. They're fast and cheap to test.
2. **Building for next year?** Add one compounding channel: founder-led content, building in public, programmatic SEO or GEO.
3. **Run each for 90 days** before you judge it, and judge it on customers, not attention.

THE 15 CHANNELS

01

Programmatic SEO

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, PLUS A LITTLE DEV WORK

Hundreds of search pages built from one template and a dataset, each answering a narrow query: "[tool] alternatives", "[tool] + [tool] integration", "[job] salary in [city]".

Start this week

1. List 50 queries your buyers type that follow one pattern. Check them in a keyword tool for real search volume.
2. Build one page by hand and make it genuinely useful. If you wouldn't read it, Google won't rank it.
3. Template it, publish 20, and wait 6 to 8 weeks before you publish 200.

Watch out: Thin pages get de-indexed. Every page needs data or an answer a reader can't get elsewhere.

02

Channel partners

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: REVENUE SHARE, USUALLY 10 TO 30%

Companies that already sell to your buyer resell or refer you: agencies, consultancies, resellers, implementation partners.

Start this week

1. Write down who your customers already pay before they find you. Those are your partners.
2. Offer three of them a revenue share and do the first deal with them yourself.
3. Give partners a one-page pitch and a demo account, then hold one call a month.

Watch out: Partners sell what is easy. If your product needs explaining, they won't push it until you've proven it sells.

03

App marketplaces

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: INTEGRATION BUILD TIME

Listing inside the platforms your buyers already use: Slack, HubSpot, Salesforce, Shopify, Zapier, Chrome.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Pick the one platform most of your customers already live in.
> 2. Ship the smallest integration that's useful on day one, and write the listing around the job it does.
> 3. Ask your first 10 users to leave a review. Marketplace ranking leans heavily on them.

> **Watch out:** You're building on someone else's platform. They can change the rules, the ranking or the API.

04

Newsletter ads

SPEED: FAST · COST: FROM A FEW HUNDRED DOLLARS A SLOT

Buying a sponsored slot in a newsletter your buyers already read.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Ask five customers which newsletters they actually open. Buy from that list, not from a directory.
> 2. Start with one small newsletter, one placement, one offer. A free resource beats "book a demo".
> 3. Track with a dedicated link and judge it on signups, not clicks.

> **Watch out:** One send tells you little. Buy two or three in the same newsletter before you decide.

05

Generative engine optimization (GEO)

SPEED: SLOW · COST: TIME

Getting cited when people ask ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity or Gemini for a recommendation in your category.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Ask the assistants the five questions your buyers ask. Note who gets recommended and which pages they cite.
> 2. Get onto those sources: comparison pages, Reddit threads, reviews, "best tools for" lists.
> 3. Publish pages that answer one question clearly, with facts an assistant can quote.

> **Watch out:** Hard to measure. Add "how did you hear about us" to signup and count the AI answers.

06

Founder dinners

SPEED: FAST · COST: DINNER FOR 10, PLUS YOUR TIME

A small dinner, 8 to 12 people, all your ideal customers, on a topic they care about. You host, you don't pitch.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Pick a topic your buyers argue about. That's the invitation.
> 2. Invite 30 to get 10. Ask one respected guest first, and name them in the other invites.
> 3. Follow up the next day with a note, a summary of the conversation, and nothing else.

> **Watch out:** The pitch kills it. The dinner earns the meeting. The meeting is where you sell.

07

Affiliates

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: COMMISSION ON REVENUE

Paying people a commission for every customer they send you: creators, consultants, existing customers.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Start with customers who already recommend you. Ask them first.
> 2. Offer a commission big enough to notice, and pay it on time, every time.
> 3. Give affiliates swipe copy, a demo video and their own tracked link.

> **Watch out:** Most affiliates send nothing. A handful send almost everything. Recruit for the few.

08

Reddit marketing

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: TIME

Being useful in the subreddits your buyers use, as a person, until people ask what you're building.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Find the five subreddits where your buyers ask for help. Read the rules of each.
> 2. Answer questions properly for two weeks before you mention your product once.
> 3. When you post, post the lesson, not the link, and disclose that you built it.

> **Watch out:** Reddit spots marketing fast, and a ban is public. Be a member first.

09

Referral programs

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: THE REWARD

Rewarding customers for bringing other customers.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Only start once customers already refer you without being asked. A program amplifies love, it doesn't create it.
> 2. Reward both sides, and make the reward something they'd actually want.
> 3. Ask at the happiest moment: right after a win, not on day one.

> **Watch out:** If nobody refers you today, fix the product before you build a program.

10

Building in public

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, AND SOME NERVE

Sharing your real numbers, decisions and mistakes as you go, so people follow the company before they need it.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Pick the numbers you'll share every week and keep the format fixed.
> 2. Share decisions and mistakes, not just wins. The misses are what people trust.
> 3. Put one clear next step at the end: the newsletter, the waitlist, the product.

> **Watch out:** Decide what stays private (client names, contract values) before the first post, not after.

11

Influencer marketing

SPEED: FAST · COST: PER POST, VARIES WIDELY

Paying creators your buyers already follow to post about you.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Pick creators by who follows them, not how many. Ask for an audience breakdown.
> 2. Brief them on the problem and let them write it in their own voice.
> 3. Pay for a test post before a package, and track with their own link.

> **Watch out:** Views are easy to buy. Customers aren't. One launch can do millions of views and almost no users.

12

A big launch day

SPEED: FAST · COST: TIME AND FAVOURS

Concentrating everything into one day: the founder's post, the team, customers, investors and partners all sharing at once.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Line up 50 people four days before who'll comment in the first hour.
> 2. Give the post two asks: comment below, and the link. They're separate funnels.
> 3. Plan the second post now. The second launch is often the one that converts.

> **Watch out:** A launch is a window, not a day. Plan the week after as carefully as the morning of.

13

Founder-led content on LinkedIn

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, OR A GHOSTWRITER

The founder posts several times a week about the problem, the customers and the company, so buyers know them before they need them.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Write down 10 things you've seen that your buyers haven't. That's your first 10 posts.
> 2. Post three times a week for 90 days before you judge it.
> 3. Grade posts on saves, profile views and DMs, not reach.

> **Watch out:** Reach is the wrong scoreboard. A post with huge reach can bring seven followers and no signups.

14

Paid ads

SPEED: FAST · COST: AD SPEND, PLUS TESTING BUDGET

Buying reach on Google, LinkedIn, Meta or Reddit and paying per click or per thousand views.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Start with search ads on the terms people type when they already want what you sell.
> 2. Send ads to a page with one offer and one form.
> 3. Set a test budget you can lose, and kill anything that hasn't produced a customer by the end of it.

> **Watch out:** Ads multiply what already converts. If your page doesn't convert organically, ads make it expensive.

15

Warm intros through your network

SPEED: FAST · COST: FAVOURS

Asking people who know you to introduce you to people who could buy.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. List 50 people who'd take your call. Next to each, write two people they know that you'd want to meet.
> 2. Write the intro for them: three lines they can forward unchanged.
> 3. Report back after every intro, whatever happened. It's how you get the next one.

> **Watch out:** It runs out. Use it for your first customers while you build a channel that doesn't.

THE ONE PAGE VERSION

1. Pick one fast channel and one compounding channel. Ignore the other thirteen for 90 days.
2. Find out where your buyers already are before you pick: ask five of them.
3. Judge every channel on customers, never on views.
4. Start where you have an unfair advantage: a network, an audience, a platform your buyers live in.
5. Anything built on someone else's platform can be taken away. Own the email list.

Francisco Gost writes The Draft, a weekly letter on how top 1% startups crush organic marketing, at franciscogost.com

Partner at RallyUp. 21.3M+ impressions generated for B2B founders and execs.